

Can the World Make Room for a Developed China?

Zhihu column · 2025-12-06

There is a proposition about China's rise that almost everyone takes for granted, so obvious it goes without saying: the market space this world affords the developed countries is fixed. If China becomes a developed country, it must mean that an equal number of people will be cast down from developed-country status.

A nation of 1.4 billion can only rise by pulling down a billion two hundred million of the developed world.

Obama thought so; the punditry of Europe, America, and Japan says so; and the hot takes of Chinese social media agree with them down to the last word. Yet China's official diplomatic line insists the opposite: the world is big enough to make room for a rising China. Is this merely a propaganda posture, or does it rest on some real foundation?

Let us analyze the question.

Developed countries cannot exist on their own; they depend upon the developing countries. The wealth of the advanced countries rests on more than the completion of their own infrastructure. More importantly, they hold the commanding heights of the production chain, occupying a monopoly, or near-monopoly, position in many industries, while pouring large surpluses into research and development to perpetuate that monopoly. Because capital flows disproportionately into R&D, advanced manufacturing, and financial services, the labor force of the developed countries is dominated by white-collar workers, professionals, and technical experts, whose incomes are high. The existence of the developed countries, however, is grounded in the existence of a great many non-developed countries. These occupy the middle and lower reaches of the production chain, hold no monopoly position, and see their product prices driven low. Their workers are chiefly manual laborers on low incomes. Between the developed and the non-developed countries, value is transferred through the exchange of products and services. Clearly, the developed countries drain away a vast quantity of surplus value from the non-developed ones — and at least where the great powers are concerned, this is the fundamental basis of their being developed at all.

We choose four points in time — 2010 (when China had essentially completed its industrialization), 2024 (the present), 2040 (the latest date by which China's rise could be complete), and 2050 — and, taking the non-agricultural working-age population as our measure, we examine roughly how many

people this world can actually sustain at developed-country standards. Figures for the future are uncertain, and some data are imprecise, but they still reflect the underlying structural relations.

We first set aside the agricultural population, for in most non-developed countries the produce of the great mass of farmers never enters the market, let alone the global value chain. Secondly, we count only the working-age population, which better captures the economic ratios among countries. We therefore calculate only the non-agricultural share of the working-age population.

The data used in this article come from the statistics and projections of the World Bank, the United Nations, and other organizations. Projections of the future may deviate somewhat from reality, yet the broad trends still come through. Because the modernization of agriculture in the developed countries is complete and their farm populations have remained essentially stable, we estimate their agricultural populations in 2040 and 2050 to be roughly what they were in 2024. For other countries, we extrapolate the agricultural share of employment along the trend of the last twenty years, or draw on figures from research studies.

In 2010, China became the world's largest industrial power, but its photovoltaic, large-aircraft, chip, and smartphone sectors — the high-end industries — had yet to show any conspicuous development. They posed no challenge to the developed countries; on the contrary, industrial expansion increased China's demand for their components and high-end equipment. In scientific research, China's share of published papers remained very low by comparison with Europe and America. In the Western world, though the "China threat" theory had never quite died, the timetable for worrying about China rising into a scientific and technological superpower was set far into the future; it was not treated as a very real threat.

As the table below shows, the non-agricultural working-age population of the developed countries stood at 22.20 percent of the world total. That is to say, by the experience of 2010, among all those engaged in capitalist production worldwide, a little over one person in five could live at developed-country standards.

类别	国家/地区	劳动年龄人口(百万)	农业人口比重	非农劳动年龄人口(百万)
发达国家	美国	208	2%	204
	欧盟	296	6%	284
	日本	81	4%	78
	韩国	36	7%	33
	加拿大	24	2%	24
	澳大利亚	15	3%	15
	新西兰	3	7%	3
	新加坡	4	1%	4
	中国台湾	19	5%	18
	中国香港	5	0%	5
	以色列	5	2%	5
	瑞士	5	2%	5
	总和	701		678
全球	全球	4560	38%	3355
	发达国家占比			22.20%

Table 1. Non-agricultural working-age population, 2010

By 2024, China's high-end industries had erupted across the board. Its impact on the developed world — Europe, America, Japan, and Korea — is now visible on every front. At the same time, the developed countries' suppression of China's industrial upgrading has grown ever more extreme. Some now go so far as to think war is inevitable, because the world cannot hold both China and the Western powers as developed countries at once.

Likewise, as the table below shows, the expansion of global capitalism has indeed enlarged the pie: the original developed countries now account for a smaller share of the world — only 18 percent. Had China never existed, the goods of developed-country firms would sell more easily, against weaker competition. But if China also joins the ranks of the developed, the combined non-agricultural labor share of China plus the old developed countries reaches 38 percent — clearly beyond what the capitalist system can accommodate (the 20-some percent). This is precisely why, as Chinese scholars and Zhihu commentators all know, the great powers of Europe, America, and Japan can accept South Korea's rise to developed status, and accept Taiwan's development into a developed region, yet cannot accept China's.

类别	国家/地区	劳动年龄人口(百万)	农业人口比重	非农劳动年龄人口(百万)
发达国家	美国	220	2%	216
	欧盟	286	4%	275
	英国	43	1%	43
	日本	73	3%	71
	韩国	36	5%	34
	加拿大	27	2%	24
	澳大利亚	18	2%	18
	新西兰	3	6%	3
	新加坡	5	0%	5
	中国台湾	16	5%	15
	中国香港	5	0%	5
	以色列	6	1%	6
	瑞士	6	2%	6
	总和	744		721
寻求升级的主要国家	中国大陆	977	22%	762
全球	全球（2023）	5300	26%	3922
	发达国家占比			18.40%
	中国+发达国家占全球比例			38%

Table 2. Non-agricultural working-age population, 2024

Is the final resolution then one of the two zero-sum outcomes — either Europe and America succeed in suppressing China's rise and trap it in the so-called "middle-income trap," or China annihilates the high-end industries of the West and takes their place?

If we take it that China completes its comprehensive rise within fifteen years, what will the world look like by 2040?

The table below shows the shares of the global non-agricultural working-age population held in 2040 by the developed countries and by China. By 2040, the further expansion of global capitalist production — the industrialization of many non-industrial countries, and the entry of many primary industrial countries into mid- and low-end manufacturing — will have greatly enlarged the economic pie. Even so, with China and the original developed countries together continuing to hold the high end of the industries and maintaining developed-country standards, they will still be only 28.7 percent of the world; and after 2040, that share will go on shrinking. This may be China's strategy: to push the capitalist pie to grow quickly by exporting industrial capacity and infrastructure, by exporting surplus capital. If the pie grows, competition between China and the old developed countries ceases to be a zero-sum game, and China's peaceful rise becomes possible. (Of course, this analysis establishes only a possibility, not a necessity; no one can guarantee that no political leader or force will start a war for reasons of its own.)

类别	国家/地区	劳动年龄人口(百万)	农业人口比重	非农劳动年龄人口(百万)
发达国家 (假设)	美国 (UN预测)	229	2%	224
	欧盟	247	4%	237
	英国	47	1%	47
	日本	60	3%	48
	韩国	27	5%	26
	加拿大	27	2%	24
	澳大利亚	20	2%	19
	新西兰	3	6%	3
	新加坡	5	0%	5
	中国台湾	13	5%	12
	中国香港	5	0%	5
	以色列	6	1%	6
	瑞士	6	2%	6
	中国大陆 (世界银行预测总数, 农业比例参考国内研究预测中2035年数据)	859	10%	773
	总和			1435
全球	全球 (总人口UN预测, 按照2000年到2022年趋势 (40%-26%) 推算, 2024全球农业就业占比在16%)	5920	16%	4973
	发达国家 (不含中国) 占全球比例			13.30%
	发达国家 (含中国) 占全球比例			28.7%

Table 3. Non-agricultural working-age population, 2040 (projection)

If no war breaks out, then through the 2020s and 2030s China and the old developed countries will pass through every sort of jostling — trade wars, supply-chain wars over chips and rare earths — and then gradually merge into coexistence. China will most likely take the center of the stage; but since the pie keeps growing, everyone can still get a share of business, and in the end the parties will discover that competition merely profits others, and that cooperation pays better.

If the world pattern after 2040 remains what it is, with China and the developed countries of Europe, America, Japan, and Korea — a little over 20 percent of humanity — holding the high end of the production chain while the remaining seventy-plus percent occupy its middle and lower reaches, this international division of labor naturally benefits China and the old developed countries, but it stands as an obstacle on the road of every latecomer nation striving to become developed.

By 2050, with the rise of new industrial powers such as India, which possess real technological capacity and an industrial base, a fresh shock will hit the world's industrial order. At that point, will the world still be able to make room for these countries to upgrade to developed status?

As the table below shows, by 2050 the developed countries, China included, have fallen to 25.5 percent of the world — but the next wave of aspirant countries adds up to 24.8 percent. If India and others rise to developed status as they hope, the non-agricultural working-age population of the developed countries would reach 50 percent of the world — which, by the historical benchmark of

2010, is plainly impossible. Count in the newly industrializing countries with real strength and ambition — Egypt, Bangladesh, Indonesia, Morocco, South Africa — and the share rises toward 60 percent, which is even more impossible.

类别	国家/地区	劳动年龄人口(百万)	农业人口比重	非农劳动年龄人口(百万)
发达国家	美国（UN预测值）	231	2%	226
	欧盟（相比2010年代下降5000万）	240	4%	237
	英国（按照2040年预测值）	47	1%	47
	日本	57	3%	48
	韩国	24	5%	26
	加拿大	27	2%	24
	澳大利亚	20	2%	19
	新西兰	3	6%	3
	新加坡	5	0%	5
	中国台湾	13	5%	12
	中国香港	5	0%	5
	以色列	6	1%	6
	瑞士	6	2%	6
	中国大陆（取决于2025年到2035年之间的出生人口，预测值从7亿到7.7亿均存在，取高值7.7亿）	770	4%	739
	总和			1403
寻求升级的主要国家	印度	1134.5	25.70%	843
	越南（当前26.5%，按当前趋势推测）	69	15%	59
	墨西哥（按当前趋势推测）	98	5%	93
	土耳其	57	10%	51
	伊朗(当前15%)	64	10%	58
	沙特(当前6%)	34	5%	32
	马来西亚（当前10%）	30	5%	29
	巴西（当前9%）	136	5%	129
	俄罗斯（当前18%）	82	10%	74
	总和			1368
全球	全球（UN预测人口，农业就业占比基于2040年取值和减少趋势取10%）	6110	10%	5499
	发达国家占全球比例			23.50%
	冲击发达国家占全球比例			24.80%

Table 4. Non-agricultural working-age population, 2050 (projection)

Thus, by 2050 the global capitalist division of labor will face its greatest challenge since the 1990s. If China's rise has already made the Western powers uneasy, the rise of India and its peers will confront China and the other developed countries with a matter of life and death. China's rise was accomplished against the background of global industrialization; the pie was growing, and it gave China and the old developed countries room for coexistence. But when India and others likewise storm the high-end manufacturing industries and seek to become technological powers, the world truly cannot accommodate so many countries "developing" all at once. The reason is not any shortage of natural resources; it is that the so-called developed countries are themselves built upon the existence of a great mass of less-developed countries, as the labor theory of value reveals. The likely end result is a restructuring of the capitalist order: wages in the developed countries and the new industrial countries will move toward balance, the new industrial countries will take up some high-end industries, and the developed countries will be forced to pick up some mid- and low-end industries again.

This article was originally published on Zhihu (in Chinese): <https://zhuanlan.zhihu.com/p/1980582259082928363> Author: 最最遥远的路 · Zhihu profile: <https://www.zhihu.com/people/zui-zui-yao-yuan-de-lu-32/posts>

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